

Passive Voice: the basics

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

The passive puts the receiver of the action first. To build it:

- 1 Use be + past participle — The letter was sent yesterday.
- 2 Make the active object the new subject — They clean it → It is cleaned.
- 3 Add 'by + doer' only if it matters — ...by the manager.

Only 'be' carries the tense (is/was/has been). Use the passive when the doer is unknown, obvious, or unimportant.

At a glance

Active	Passive
They build houses.	Houses are built .
Someone stole my bike.	My bike was stolen .
They have sold the car.	The car has been sold .
A famous architect designed it.	It was designed by a famous architect.

Learning objectives

- Can form the passive with be + past participle in the present and past (CEFR B1).
- Can transform active sentences into passive ones, making the object the subject.
- Can decide when to include or omit the agent with 'by'.



Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Passive Voice: the basics · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. This bridge ____ in 1932.

- | | |
|--------------|----------------|
| A. built | B. was built |
| C. was build | D. is building |

2. Make it passive: 'They make these shoes in Italy.'

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| A. These shoes are made in Italy. | B. These shoes make in Italy. |
| C. These shoes are make in Italy. | D. These shoes is made in Italy. |

3. My car ____ last week — I've reported it to the police.

- | | |
|--------------|---------------|
| A. stole | B. was stolen |
| C. was stole | D. has stolen |

4. The report ____ already ____ to all staff.

- | | |
|---------------------|--------------------|
| A. has / sent | B. has been / sent |
| C. have been / sent | D. was / send |

5. Which sentence correctly adds the doer?

- | | |
|---|---|
| A. The Mona Lisa was painted by Leonardo. | B. The Mona Lisa was painted from Leonardo. |
| C. The Mona Lisa painted by Leonardo. | D. The Mona Lisa was paint by Leonardo. |

6. Choose the sentence that should stay ACTIVE (can't be passive).

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|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| A. The accident happened at noon. | B. They cleaned the office. |
| C. Someone opened the door. | D. The company hired her. |

7. Coffee ____ in over 70 countries.

- | | |
|------------|-------------|
| A. grows | B. is grown |
| C. is grow | D. grown |

8. Correct this: 'The window broke by the boys.' (they did it)

- | | |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| A. The window was broken by the boys. | B. The window was break by the boys. |
| C. The window broke by the boys. | D. The window is broke by the boys. |

9. A decision ____ at the meeting tomorrow.

- | | |
|-----------------|-----------------|
| A. will make | B. will be made |
| C. will be make | D. is made |

10. When is the passive the BEST choice?

- | | |
|---|--------------------------------------|
| A. When the doer is unknown or unimportant. | B. When you want to name who did it. |
| C. When the verb has no object. | D. When the sentence is a command. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **B. was built** — Past passive = was/were + past participle: 'was built'.
2. **A. These shoes are made in Italy.** — Present passive = are + past participle: 'are made'.
3. **B. was stolen** — Past passive: 'My car was stolen'.
4. **B. has been / sent** — Present perfect passive = has been + participle: 'has been sent'.
5. **A. The Mona Lisa was painted by Leonardo.** — The agent takes 'by': 'was painted by Leonardo'.
6. **A. The accident happened at noon.** — 'Happen' has no object, so it can't be passive.
7. **B. is grown** — Present passive: 'Coffee is grown in over 70 countries'.
8. **A. The window was broken by the boys.** — With a doer, use the passive: 'was broken by the boys'.
9. **B. will be made** — Future passive = will be + participle: 'will be made'.
10. **A. When the doer is unknown or unimportant.** — Use the passive when the doer is unknown, obvious or unimportant.